

Chapter 82_1 - Not Demon

Heavenly Auspicious Imperial Lord? That Penglai Lord Heavenly Auspicious Imperial Lord? Now that she wasn't even a demon, why would he come to interrogate her for no good reason?

Penglai Realm was a divine mountain like Zhaoyao, possessing semi-divine bloodlines. Especially Heavenly Auspicious Imperial Lord, whose magical power was formidable, definitely not inferior to Chu Qingqiu in her prime. A thousand years ago, Penglai had been the leader of the immortal realm, but later for some unknown reason, it withdrew from the martial world, becoming isolated from the world and rarely appearing before people.

In her previous life, it wasn't until after Ning Fuyi became a demon that Penglai symbolically fought a few battles with her, so there had never been much contact.

Seeing that Ning Fuyi didn't respond, the people outside spoke again: "Left Envoy of Penglai, Wen Yaojun, here by order of Heavenly Auspicious Imperial Lord. We hope Miss Ning will cooperate."

The immortal energy outside was very heavy. The visitors not only had powerful cultivation but were also numerous. Ning Fuyi knew she couldn't escape, so she put away Lovesickness and reached out to open the door.

Outside, dark clouds gathered, but the armor on several people all had divine light, momentarily blindingly bright. Ning Fuyi raised her hand to shield her eyes before she could see the people clearly.

Standing at the very front was the man who had spoken earlier, wearing light silver armor with a cape behind him that shone with moonlight-like radiance. He was tall with sharp, well-proportioned features and extremely thin lips.

His eyes looked down - unreachably high: "Miss Ning, please."

Ning Fuyi's gaze moved backward, seeing behind him a row of people in armor standing in formation, all holding identical spears, imposing and dignified.

At the very back, in an inconspicuous place, stood a person wearing a hood. Just standing there, they emanated layers of pressure, showing extremely formidable cultivation.

"Using such a grand formation to invite someone," Ning Fuyi lowered her hands and withdrew her gaze. "I'm just a small cultivator. I wonder what heinous crime I've committed to be treated this way by Penglai?"

"Miss Ning jests. These are our Penglai immortal soldiers, they mean no harm," that Wen Yaojun said without looking aside. "All the sect leaders and elders are waiting in Cloud Deep Hall. Please don't delay any more time."

Ning Fuyi stared at him for two glances, then suddenly turned toward the door: "Ping An!"

She could go, but the tension in her heart just now was definitely not fake. She still needed someone to check on Chu Qingqiu before she could feel at ease.

The white dog that had already been startled came running out with whimpering sounds, cowering fearfully at Ning Fuyi's feet.

"Ping An, I'll go and return quickly. I haven't fed you today. If you're hungry, go find Qiuyi for something to eat," Ning Fuyi said with lowered head as usual, then looked up with a half-smile.

"Let's go," she said.

Ning Fuyi had never felt the road to Cloud Deep Hall was so long. Along the way, disciples who had been awakened occasionally peeked out to look. Seeing her being escorted by a group of immortal soldiers, they all whispered among themselves.

"Isn't that the young sect leader? Why are Penglai people arresting her?"

"I heard it's related to the demon clan."

"Ah? Ning Fuyi is from the demon clan?"

"Shh, I also heard people talking randomly. Penglai came this time specifically for the demon clan's chaotic affairs. If she has nothing to do with the demon clan, why arrest her?"

"This matter is still undecided - what are you all gossiping about!" Feng Ge, still wearing morning robes, sternly drove away the disciples watching the excitement.

Liu Wenzhu was also awakened by this commotion. She was about to step forward when Feng Ge grabbed her: "Those are Penglai people. What use would you going there be? Hurry and find Divine Venerable Chu Ling! I'll handle things here!"

"But Yiyi¹ she..." Liu Wenzhu bit her pale lips, then stamped her feet angrily and turned into flowing light, rushing toward Tranquil Mountain Palace.

Under everyone's gaze, Ning Fuyi stepped up the white jade steps. The hall doors slowly opened, and under everyone's gaze, she walked inside.

Except for the day when the sect leader was invested, this was when Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate had the most people gathered. Mei Chengsi, looking pleased with himself, stood at the main position with two protectors, while Pingyao, Jingshan, Yuanming, and the Chief Elder stood on both sides, all with grave expressions.

Yuan Ming was still here, so Chu Qingqiu's situation should be fine. Ning Fuyi relaxed slightly, her gaze lingering on him for a while longer.

The other teaching elders stood on both sides, along with several inner sect managing disciples, all whispering among themselves.

Rong Jin and Hong Ying, who had one arm in a sling, were also among them. When Rong Jin saw her, he wanted to step forward but was stopped by Hong Ying's outstretched hand, gesturing for him not to act rashly.

"Wen Yaojun, now that the person has been brought, let's begin," Mei Chengsi seemed to have never been so elated. He waved his hand to close the hall doors and walked down the steps with measured strides. "Ning Fuyi, do you know why you're being interrogated?"

"If you have something to say, say it quickly. If you have to fart, fart quickly². You're being evasive - how would I know?" Ning Fuyi said coldly.

"Truly sharp-tongued," Mei Chengsi smiled. He turned to face Wen Yaojun. "Wen Yaojun, may I borrow the astrolabe?"

Wen Yaojun stood with hands behind his back, raising his hand to conjure a disk-shaped object. The disk was carved with dense ancient script. He rotated it twice with his other hand, and a seven-colored bright light suddenly rose above the astrolabe. The light spread into a circle, and some fragmented scenes appeared in the center.

Ning Fuyi immediately glared, and gasps of surprise rang out around her, as if everyone had seen something extremely shocking.

The figures in those fragments were all her, yet also not her. A woman in black robes stood atop the sun and moon, Emei Thorns in her hand stained with fresh blood. As blood splattered toward the sky, countless thunderbolts fell, the immortal sects were severely damaged, countless cultivators died in mid-air, the mortal realm suffered disaster, and mountains, rivers, and seas were destroyed in an instant.

This scene was truly horrifying. Even the elders looked up in shock, unable to speak: "This, this is..."

"The Imperial Lord spent a thousand years in seclusion, accumulating a thousand years of opportunity to activate the astrolabe, finally finding the whereabouts of this world-destroying person - hidden within Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate! This woman has extremely yin meridians³, born as a demonic evil star, harboring demonic nature. That's why I was sent to investigate the truth," Wen Yaojun raised his hand to put away the astrolabe, looking down at Ning Fuyi from above.

"Miss Ning, do you have anything to confess?" he said.

Ning Fuyi's heart trembled. She clenched her fists within her sleeves, one corner of her lip curving up: "Confess? What broken magical device - it says I'm a demon so I am? I've never done the things shown above. What do I have to confess!"

"Though the astrolabe shows prophetic events, your hidden demonic nature is real! You harbor demonic nature within your body - don't you know this yourself?" Wen Yaojun shouted sternly.

He summoned another magical device from his hand - a golden, brilliant Vajra Demon-Subduing Staff⁴. As soon as the staff appeared, it flew above everyone's heads, illuminating the hall's incredibly high ceiling with Buddhist light.

"What nonsense Heavenly Auspicious Imperial Lord - trumping up charges where none exist⁵. Randomly pinning a crime on my head and wanting to interrogate me - how ridiculous!" Ning Fuyi said angrily. "You ignore the truly chaotic demon clan and instead target me, a small disciple. So this is how the great Penglai bullies the weak and fears the strong!"

"Stop resisting. Whether you're a demon or not, the Demon-Subduing Staff will determine. Our arguments don't count!" Wen Yaojun said impatiently, raising his hand to press down the staff. The onlookers finally couldn't stand it anymore and spoke up one after another.

"Left Envoy! Fuyi was raised under our disciples' watch. She's the daughter of Condensing Heaven's sect leader - how could she have demonic nature!" Rong Jin rushed out from the crowd, cupping his hands. "Her cultivation is insufficient and her body is weak. The Demon-Subduing Staff is an ancient divine artifact. One strike from it would damage the five internal organs whether demon or not. Please reconsider, Left Envoy!"

Hong Ying and Feng Ge at the side also stepped forward: "Yes, sect leaders and elders, Ning Fuyi has always had low cultivation. How could she be a demon? Moreover, this past year she's followed Divine Venerable Chu Ling in subduing demons and eliminating evil, repeatedly achieving merit. She not only resolved the urgent crisis in the underworld but also quelled the Qi Kingdom rebellion⁶, rescuing fellow disciples from a tiger's den⁷. She's done so many good deeds - how could she be a demon!"

Other fellow disciples wanted to plead for her, but were shaken by a humming sound from the Demon-Subduing Staff, unable to speak further.

"I'm acting under orders. Please don't make things difficult for everyone," Wen Yaojun said seriously.

"Wen Yaojun, no matter what, Ning Fuyi is a disciple of our sect. For Penglai to consider her a demon based on just an astrolabe and use the Demon-Subduing Staff on her - this isn't appropriate," Elder Pingyao also frowned as she spoke.

Before Wen Yaojun could respond, Mei Chengsi at the side smiled and stepped in front of her: "Pingyao, Penglai Realm was the leader of immortal sects a thousand years ago. Now they're just thinking of the world. If Ning Fuyi really is a demon and causes chaos in the world later, we'll regret it deeply."

"Sect Leader! How can you convict someone based on undone deeds! This way, anyone you want to deal with in the future can be labeled as a demon, and you can righteously kill them. How can this be called righteous cultivation!" Rong Jin's handsome face flushed red as he again faced Mei Chengsi directly.

"Silence!" Mei Chengsi's face immediately darkened, raising his hand to summon fierce fire. Fortunately, Rong Jin reacted quickly and blocked with a wooden shield, though he still retreated repeatedly.

"Senior Brother!" Ning Fuyi quickly helped support him.

Mei Chengsi withdrew the fierce fire and sneered with hands behind his back: "What good deeds? The matter of Ning Fuyi's contract with a demonic beast hasn't been judged by the sect yet. That qilin is vicious by nature and even injures people's lives. It has long been demonized and deserves death! If you hand it over, this venerable might still plead for you."

Ning Fuyi was almost laughed to anger by his expression. Her fists clenched tighter, no longer able to control the rage in her heart: "Qilin is a divine beast, not a demonic beast. Since she's contracted with me, I naturally won't hand her over. If the sect leader wants her, you're welcome to try!"

As soon as these words were spoken, a prayer bead on her wrist suddenly trembled.

Footnotes:

¹ **Yiyi (衣衣)** - An affectionate nickname for Ning Fuyi

² **If you have to fart, fart quickly (有屁快放)** - A crude but common Chinese expression meaning "get to the point" or "stop beating around the bush"

³ **Extremely yin meridians (至阴之脉)** - In Chinese cultivation, refers to an extremely negative/dark energy constitution

⁴ **Vajra Demon-Subduing Staff (金刚降魔杵)** - A Buddhist ritual object used to subdue demons and evil spirits

⁵ **Trumping up charges where none exist (欲加之罪何患无辞)** - A classical Chinese idiom meaning "if you want to condemn someone, you can always find a pretext"

⁶ **Qi Kingdom rebellion (岐国之乱)** - A previous incident mentioned in the story

⁷ **Tiger's den (虎穴)** - An idiom meaning a dangerous place